

THE KOREAN WAR

1950-1953

Military Opposition to Communist Aggression

Before the Outbreak of War

For most of the first half of the 20th century (1905-1945), the Korean Peninsula was part of the Japanese empire, initially as a protectorate.

At the end of World War II, the Soviet Union (from the north) and American troops (from the south) entered Korea.

As early as 1943, during an Allied Conference in Cairo, it was assumed that Japan would be driven out of the territories it had illegally seized and that Korea would become a democratic and independent state.

Kim Il-sung (1950)

Rhee Syngman (1945)

Refugees from North Korea

In the current changing international situation, I support the desire of Korean people to unify.

— Stalin in a letter to the Chinese leader Mao

September 6th, 1945

September 1948

August 1948

End of 1949

June 25th, 1950

Outbreak of War on the Korean Peninsula

North Korea attacks South Korea, crossing the 38th parallel. The Korean War begins.

UN Security Council resolution 82 condemns the attack and calls for the withdrawal of the communist state's troops from South Korea.

Forces

NORTH KORA

ok. 200 000

+ 30 000 reservists

274 tanks

260 aircraft

SOUTH KORA

65 000

+ 33 000 reservists

No armored units

No air force

No anti-aircraft artillery

June 27th, 1950

UN Security Council Resolution 83 calls on member states to assist South Korea, and Resolution 84 (July 7th, 1950) authorizes the US to lead the military operation in Korea under the UN flag. At first, American troops are sent to the peninsula, joined then by troops from other allied countries.

UN (United Nations)

An international organization founded in 1945 on the initiative of the anti-Nazi coalition led by the USA and Great Britain. Its goal was, among others, to maintain peace and security in the world.

In the Korean war, South Korea was supported by a total of 15 countries. Apart from the USA, the largest number of forces were sent by: Great Britain, Turkey, Canada and Australia. Most of the countries supporting South Korea sent symbolic support to the Korean Peninsula, most often not exceeding 1 thousand soldiers. These were: Belgium, Ethiopia, France, the Philippines, Greece, the Netherlands, Colombia, New Zealand, Thailand, and the Union of South Africa. Luxembourg sent 44 soldiers to fight.

Soviet Union and UN

The Soviet Union belonged to the United Nations from its inception. However, the Soviet Union UN representative boycotted the deliberations, during which it was decided to provide international support to South Korea.

The Armed Conflict

Military operations on the Korean Peninsula: two stages.

1950 STAGE 1 war maneuvers 1951 STAGE 2 war positioning 1953

Stage 1 / War Maneuvers

June 25th - September 15th, 1950

With significant advantage in men and equipment, the Korean People's Army occupies 95% of the peninsula. UN troops are pushed back towards the port of Busan (the so-called **Busan Perimeter**).

July 14th-21st, 1950

Battle of Deajeon (aka Tejdon). The US 24th Infantry Division is crushed by the Korean People's Army. Commander William Dean is captured.

September 10th - October 25th, 1950

A UN naval landing at Inchon triggers a retreat of North Korean troops. UN troops regain the southern part of the peninsula and cross the 38th parallel. At the end of October 1950, UN forces have occupied almost the entire peninsula.

September 15th-19th, 1950

Battle of Inchon

The battle is part of the landing operation codenamed "Chromite". The action ends in victory for the UN forces. The landing strike plan was developed by US General Douglas MacArthur.

5th, 6th and 11th of September

UN planes bomb roads and bridges to Kusan, B-29 bombers strike against military targets. The operation is designed to convince the North Korean command that the landing will take place in a different location.

September 12-13

UN forces land at Kusan to confuse the North Koreans.

15th of September

The Landings

Green beach

In the morning, US forces land on the northern tip of the island of Wollmido. By noon they have taken the entire island, losing 14 soldiers.

Red beach

Soldiers are forced to use ladders to climb the steep beach defenses. The attackers are greeted with intense fire from mortars and machine guns. During the night, the North Korean defenses are broken.

Blue beach

This landing is intended to strengthen UN positions that would then allow an attack on Seoul. One landing barge is sunk by enemy gunfire, but heavy fire from American destroyers and aerial bombardment eliminates resistance from the north Koreans. As a result, UN landing forces do not encounter much resistance when landing on the beach.

14 days before the landing

The Americans send a reconnaissance mission to the Yungung-do islet at the entrance to the port of Inchon. Scouts gather information about tides, shallows and shoreline fortifications, they determine artillery positions and the numbers of North Korean troops.

September 10th

American planes drop 93 napalm bombs on the Wollmido islet to clear the area for the Americans.

September 13th and 14th

UN ships sail to the port of Inchon and fire at North Korean positions from the sea. Planes bomb targets in the port.

16th of September

The port of Inchon is occupied by the Americans.

September 17th

A North Korean counterattack by a force of 6 T-34 tanks and 200 soldiers is repelled.

September 18th

Americans capture the strategically important Kimpo airport. The airport becomes the main air base of the United Nations forces. By September 22nd, the Americans had already unloaded 6,629 military vehicles, 53,882 soldiers and over 23,000 tonnes of supplies.

Specifications

Mass 5.2 lb (2.4 kg) empty 5.8 lb (2.6 kg) loaded w/sling

Length 35.6 in (900 mm)

Barrel length 18 in (460 mm)

Cartridge 30 Carbine

Action Gas-operated (short-stroke piston), rotating bolt

Rate of fire Semi-automatic (M1A1) 750 rounds/min (M2)

Muzzle velocity 1,900 ft/s (607 m/s)

Effective firing range 300 yd (270 m)

Feed system 15- or 30-round detachable box magazine

The Battle of Inchon is an example of military brilliance in both terms of command and efficient planning. It is considered to be one of the greatest military successes in United States history. The daring landings by American forces allowed a subsequent attack on Seoul and turned the tide of the war.

War Hero

Lieutenant Baldomero López makes his way through the fortifications on Red Beach. Soon after taking this photo, he dies, throwing himself on an live grenade. Lopez was posthumously awarded the Medal of Honor.

NORTH KOREAN WAR CRIMES

Massacre on Hill 303

On August 17th, 1950, during the battle for the Busan Perimeter, on a hill 303 metres above sea level, near the city of Waegwan in South Korea, 42 prisoners of war from the United States Army were shot by troops from the Korean People's Army.

Massacre in the Suncheon tunnel

On October 30th, 1950, North Korean soldiers shot 68 American prisoners of war in the Suncheon tunnel, using Soviet Nagash rifles. Many died from hunger, cold, exhaustion and disease while still traveling to Suncheon on open railway wagons.

The Marches of Death

Over a thousand American prisoners of war died during forced marches to prisoner-of-war camps. The prisoners walked barefoot, were beaten, and starved. If they were unable to walk, they were killed. The Seoul - Pyongyang march in September 1950 lasted three weeks. American POWs had to travel 400 km. Of the 376 who set out, 296 died.

Stage 2 / Positional Warfare

July 1951

The first round of peace negotiations begins, which fail. At this point, for two years there has been fighting on the front line. Communist troops try to achieve victory by carrying out massive infantry attacks. American and South Korean air forces regularly fire at enemy ground forces.

October 26th, 1950-June 9th, 1951

The **Chinese People's Volunteers** (initially around 200,000 soldiers; although by the end of the Korean War their number had risen to over a million) enter the frontline of the fighting.

North Korea, with the support of the Chinese army, carries out a **second offensive**. UN troops retreat south and are in danger of losing Seoul.

May-June 1951

After a counteroffensive by UN forces, the front stabilizes at the so-called **Kansas-Wyoming** line, which forms the present-day border between North Korea and South Korea.

North Korean refugees fleeing south (during a second offensive), Korea, May 1st 1951

American airplane Mustang Mk. IVA. The South Korean Air Force marking is visible on the hull, Korea, 1950-1953

During trench warfare, North Korean soldiers donned civilian clothes to confuse the enemy and cross the front lines. They then organized partisan attacks behind enemy lines.

North-Korean prisoners

Two Chinese prisoners, Korea, August 1951

End of Conflict

July 27, 1953

A truce is signed in **Punmanjom** (on the border between North Korea and South Korea).

Reasons for ending hostilities:

- Death of Stalin (March 1953).
- Lack of effect from the trench warfare that had been going on for two years.
- Exhaustion of North Korea and China during a protracted war (large losses of people, destruction of industry, damaged economy).
- The threat by the US of the use of nuclear weapons.

The parties to the conflict established a **demilitarized zone** 4 km wide (2 km north and 2 km south) of the so-called **Kansas - Wyoming** demarcation line.

The Price of War

The Korean War remains the bloodiest conflict of the Cold War period. The totalitarian and genocidal actions of the communists brought huge losses to all sides both material and in human terms.

Losses

Other UN countries 3730

United States 33.6 thousand

1 789 000 American soldiers fought in the Korean War

Soldiers

China 1 million

North Korea 2 million

South Korea 1.5 million (killed and wounded)

Civilian population

North Korea 1 million

South Korea 1 million

Poland and the Korean War

Communist Propaganda

The communists eagerly wasted no time exploiting the terrible effects of the conflict to discredit the states of the free Western world, as well as to highlight the damage suffered by North Korea (in fact the brutal communist aggressor). In Communist Poland, the cases of orphans from North Korea were publicized.

During the years 1951-1953, Poland accepted 12 thousand North Korean orphans. In 1959, Kim Il-sung ordered that the children should be brought back to their homeland. Some tried to get back to Poland, which unfortunately ended tragically for them.

The real feelings of a large part of Polish society in the 1950s, living under a totalitarian communist regime, were to oppose the war. There was widespread unofficial sympathy for the US and for South Korea, but there was also hope that this Far East conflict could turn into World War III and thereby bring freedom to Poland. The hopes of Poles were well-expressed in the lines of the following poem:

*Truman, Truman, burst this bubble, it is so unbearable here
One atomic bomb and we will return to live again (...)
A second one, small but vitriolous
And we will also return to Vilnius*

— Popular rhyme in Poland at the time of Korean War

After the War

The Korean War was crucial to establishing a balance of power between the world powers (the US and the Soviet Union) and, as a result, between the Eastern bloc and the West.

The border between North Korea and South Korea, delineated as a result of military operations, was a symbolic division of the world into the communist camp and the free world of the West during the Cold War.

The conflict on the Korean Peninsula was also the first time force was used by the UN to defend security in the world and contributed to the development of the United Nations.

The Forgotten War

In the minds of many contemporary Westerners, the clash between communist forces and the forces of the free world, represented by the United Nations, which took place in Korea, remains a forgotten war, overshadowed by the subsequent wars in Vietnam and in the Persian Gulf.

Remembrance

KOREA

A **Korean War Memorial** is located in Seoul. The sculpture, called **Brothers**, commemorates the war. It depicts two brothers, soldiers from the opposing sides of the conflict, in a dramatic gesture of reconciliation.

USA

Korean War Veterans Memorial in Washington, DC

The monument was unveiled on July 27th, 1995, on the anniversary of the Korean armistice. It commemorates the sacrifice of American and UN soldiers who fought during the Korean War. The inscription on the monument reads:

Our nation honors its sons and daughters who responded to the call to defend a country they never knew and people they never met.

The Korean War in Popular Culture

In popular culture, the Korean War was recalled in the American series **M*A*S*H** (short for **Mobile Army Surgical Hospital**), broadcast between the years 1972-1983. 251 episodes were aired in 11 seasons. It tells the story of a group of US military surgeons and nurses serving in a field hospital, and features comedy elements with an anti-war message. The series was very popular, it received as many as 8 Golden Globe awards, and the final episode was watched by over 100 million viewers in the USA.